This is How We Live

By Ellen DeGeneres

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INTRODUCTION

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Modern life requires hardly any physical activity. We just push a button and stand there. Take the car window. Someone decided that having to crank the window down yourself was too hard. "I don't want to churn butter, I just want fresh air!" So we got a button to do it.

We're just so lazy. We used to have breath mints. Now we have breath strips that just dissolve on our tongue. Can we not suck anymore?

Yes, we're lazy. Yet we also can't seem to sit still. So we've started making things like GO-GURT. That's yogurt for people on the go. Let me ask you, was there a big mobility problem with yogurt before? How time-consuming was it, really?

"Hello? . . . Oh, hi, Tom . . . I've been dying to see that movie . . . Umm, no . . . I just opened up some yogurt . . . Yeah, I'm in for the night . . . No, not even later – it's the

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kind with fruit on the bottom. Well, have fun. Thanks anyway."

Power bars were made for mountain-climbing expeditions and hiking, not really made to be eaten in the car on the way to the mall. Is it really that much faster and more convenient? It takes longer to chew one bit of those things than it takes to make an entire sandwich. I don't know what they're made from, but you could insulate a house with that stuff.

There are certain things that they're coming up with that I just don't think we need. Top of the list is that moving sidewalk you find in airports. It's like a little ride in the middle of nowhere, but I don't know what function it really serves. I mean, it's fun because it moves, so if you walk while you're on it you're almost like the Bionic Woman, just flying past the people trudging beside you on the ground. But you know how hard it is to adjust to walking again once you get off that thing? And what about those people who get on there and just stand? I guess we have to thank God they found the moving sidewalk. Without it, I don't know how they'd get anywhere.

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You'd think with all these innovations that are speeding things up for us and moving us along, people would be early-or at least on time-when they're going places. But somehow, everybody's still always late. And people always say the same thing when they finally show up after you've been waiting for them. "Oh, sorry. Traffic."

"Really? How do you think I got here? Helicoptered in? I allow for it."

[And] What has happened to toilet paper in public bathrooms? It's not even one-ply anymore, is it? It's a sheer suggestion of toilet paper. It's an innuendo. It's like prosciutto, it's so thin. And if you're in a public bathroom and it's a brand-new roll that hasn't gotten started yet, just try to find the start of that toilet paper roll. Fist you turn it slowly. You think, surely I've gone around once or twice by now. Then you go fast. Maybe the wind will open up the first flap. Then you turn it the other way, thinking maybe you're going in the wrong direction. And back to the slow again. And then you find it, and it's glued down. So then you try to pull it apart but only a quarter of an inch separates and the rest stays glued. So you're pulling and

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pulling and soon you've got a five-foot-long quarter-of-an-inch strip. I don't want a streamer, I want toilet paper! So now one side is fully intact and you've got a groove cut out on the other side. Then you use your finger to try to even it out, but you never get it exactly even, so then you finally just claw at it like a wild animal. "Jesus, I just want toilet paper!"

On the other hand, some things that don't need to be made easier are being made easier. They're making these automated toilets that flush entirely on their own schedule. Sometimes they just go off randomly. You're still sitting down and suddenly it just flushes. "How dare you! I'll decide when I'm done!" And then other times it won't go off when you want it to. You sand up and stare at the toilet. Sometimes you have to fake it out. You sit back down . . .stand up! Sit down . . . stand up! Then you try tiptoeing away as if you're leaving. Nothing works.

Technology has done one beautiful thing for us. It's called the cell phone. There is now not one place in the world where a cell phone is not going off. And every cell phone

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now has its own little song. Good thing we got rid of those obnoxious rings, isn't it?

When you're on a cell phone, you can't ever have a full conversation. Usually reception is terrible, and somehow it's only bad on your side. The person talking to you has no idea that you have bad reception. They're rambling on and on and you've got your finger jammed in your ear. You're shushing people on the street, ducking behind a Dumpster, putting your head between your knees, just so you can hear about your friend's new haircut. "What about the bangs? Are they shorter? Are the bangs shorter? THE BANGS!!"

At least if there's static you have some clue that you may get cut off. There's nothing worse than when you have crystal-clear reception and you've been rambling on for who knows how long, only to find out that the connection cut out who knows how long ago. Then you get paranoid. You're scared to talk too long ever again. Next time you're on the phone you become obsessed with checking. "So we were going to go to the cheese shop . . . Hello? Okay . . . And we knew we were having white wine. . . Still there? All

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right. And I thought, what kind of cheese would go with. . .? Did I lose you? Okay . . . And I like Muenster . . . "

Even if you're on a regular phone at home, you'll be interrupted somehow. You'll be interrupted by call-waiting most likely. Call-waiting was intended as a convenience, but let's face it – it's really turned into a mini People's Choice awards. You find out right away who wins or loses. You're having a pleasant conversation with someone you think is a good friend, and you hear the click, and you're confident that they're going to come back to you. Then they come back and say, "I've got to take this other call." And you know what that means. They just said to the other person, "Let me get rid of this other call." That's what you just became: a call to get rid of. Then you learn to trick them the next time, when they say they've got to check on the other call. "Hey, when you come back, remind me to tell you something that somebody said about you! . . . Hello?"

Of course, you don't have to pick up call-waiting. You can get voice mail. Voice mail will pick it up for you. My favorite voice mail is the one where you insert your name

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into a robotic message, and you end up sounding more like a robot than the robot itself. "Your call has been forwarded to an automatic voice message system. El-len [or insert your name here] is not available." Is that how I say my name? Like HAL from 2001: A Space Odyssey? "Yeah, I'd like to make reservations for dinner tonight, there's four of us, and the name is El-len [or insert your name here]."

Phones have gone through such an evolution. Now we have this wireless technology that lets us talk to anybody, anywhere, anytime. Think about how far phones have come. You'll remember there was a time when there was one phone in the house, when cord was just being invented. There was a shortage of cord back then. Maybe you had a foot or two from the wall to the phone. Back then, when you said you were on the phone, you were on the phone.

Then the kitchen wall phone came along, usually a lovely mustard or an avocado green. It had a ninety-foot-long cord that allowed you to talk all round the house, cleaning tables, wrapping around dogs, so that by the time you hung up the phone, it had become this tangled wire of cord

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confusion. But what was fun about it was that every once in a while you would hold the phone upside down by the cord and let that thing spin and spin, around and around, till it found its center. Good times.

One surefire sign that things are going the wrong way? Now we have the hands-free phone so you can concentrate on the thing you're really supposed to be doing. My thought is this: Chances are, if you need both of your hands to do something, your brain should be in on it too!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier – MS
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